

# It's Your Computer

One size doesn't fit all, as you know all too well. Though most of us don't go so far as to name our computers, each Windows computer is unique - except in the case of some offices where people do nothing on them except word processing and spreadsheeting.

It's the Windows Registry that holds your personal settings - so that's where you should be headed if you want to make your computer your own.

We can think of at least five good reasons why you should tinker with the Registry. First, customisation: XP, more so than Windows 98, can be customised to one's heart's content, and Vista reportedly will be even more customisable. But customising via menus is (a) limited, and (b) not so much fun. Second, security restrictions: you don't want people to mess with your computer. Third, performance: Windows should ideally ship with a performance-tuning Wizard, but it doesn't, so we need to resort to Registry hacks. Fourth, using the Registry Editor and other tools we mention gives you a feeling of control over your computer - it's a good feeling. And finally, making Registry edits is good, clean fun. Except when you break something, of course.

In this book, we have collated a whole bunch of Registry edits. In addition, for those new to the Registry, we introduce it in terms of what it is and how it works. Then there's a chapter on how to work with Registry files and such, and another on third-party tools that give you more user-friendly control over the Registry. Included in this, the third chapter, are tools that help you optimise and repair the Registry as well. Then follow the tweaks.

There will be several more disclaimers to come, but here's the first: handle the all-powerful Registry with care!